

TheCheeseGrater

The Other Student Magazine of University College London Union



No. 2

October 2004

THIS MONTH

UCL boy screws up Tories

Fun and merriment chez Stringfellow - p.12

XFM to save...er...

Are the so-called saviours of student radio as good as the paper said? - p.12

European Social Forum

Exclusive meeting coverage. Guaranteed non-piss-taking, except for words - p.7

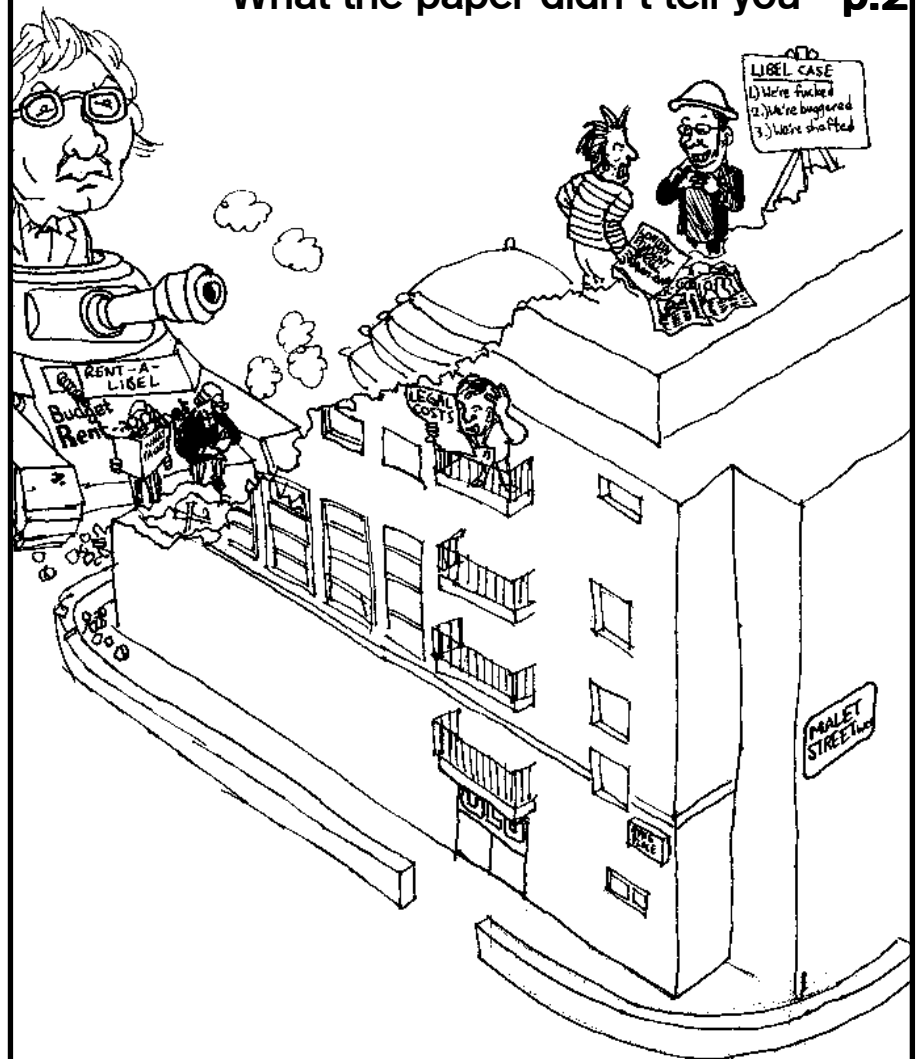
Give Us Your Fucking Money

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Honderich Hits *London Student* What the paper didn't tell you - p.2



Special report

The Honderich Affair

Did you see that article in *London Student* about the UCL professor and his thoughts on terrorism? Here's what happened afterwards, much to the credit of everyone involved...



Love letter to Alexi Duggins
from Ted Honderich, via his lawyers.
Note strange lack of kisses, scented
notepaper

ON 19 AUGUST, Ted Honderich, retired UCL professor of philosophy, gave a lecture at the Edinburgh International Book Festival. Prof. Honderich was and is the author of *After the Terror*, a book about that most original of subjects, the way forward in The Post 9/11 World. This book had already caused controversy when it was published in 2002, due to its acceptance of certain forms of terrorism under certain conditions as being conducive to creating a better world. To sum up its most controversial point, the Palestinians are justified in terrorism if the consequences are overwhelmingly good. For two years, Prof. Honderich has been vigorously denying that he is an anti-Semite or a supporter of terrorism in general. Then he issued his speech. It can't have been the

Journalistic Harm-ony

Who did the real harm - Ted Honderich to race relations or the *London Student* news desk to journalism?

Mary Grace Nguyen and
Colin Hoad

"Monsieur l'abbé, I detest what you write, but I would give my life to make it possible for you to continue to write."

[Voltaire, in a letter to M. le Riche, 6th February 1770]

ACADEMIC FREEDOM is something that philosophers of Voltaire's enlightened breed struggled for

in their lifetimes, and our culture should be seen in some ways as the fruit of their labours. Yet content such as *London Student's* take on the reaction to Professor Ted Honderich's 'Terrorism For Humanity' lecture can only make us wonder whether certain people have not lost sight of what it means to live in a free society.

Freedom of speech requires that we listen as well as speak, that we do more than swallow a few juicy sound-bites lifted completely out of context

from an article, speech or book. Not only did the author do this, but then he wrote as though handing down absolute knowledge of the lecture. Prof. Honderich's writings contain plenty of quotable lines; that one may easily quote from him, however, should not relieve us of the duty of quoting him responsibly. Alas, this simple task is too often overlooked in the pursuit of sensationalism, a trend which no doubt finds its seed in the slums of student journalism. And so to the facts



You can see why this article was shocking. "My son's had his name changed by deed poll!" shrieked Mrs. Torricke-Barton

freshest thing on the menu at Edinburgh: it was a rehash of an earlier speech he'd given in Boston in March, and the basic issues discussed seem to be the same as in *After the Terror*. Afterwards, he gave an interview that was covered by several media agencies including – unsurprisingly given the subject matter – Al-Jazeera. So far, so good.

Then, for reasons known only to themselves, some people decided that now, and only now, was the time to complain. Among those leading the charge was Sam Lebens of UCL

Union Jewish Soc., who didn't think the lecture should be posted up on UCL's website for all to see, and said so. And so it was that in early September, the whiz kids in Malet Street decided that this minor controversy should be splashed all over *London Student*. Together with a story about a King's lecturer with a thing about burkhas, this made for a nice two-page spread. Shame, then, that such a heavyweight story – by *LS* standards – was not more sensitively covered.

The person who covered it, UCL's Dex Torricke-Barton (SSEES II), is a shady character: in *LS* he goes by such curious *noms de plume* as 'Dex Barton-Torrick' or 'Dex Barton'. To us, though, he'll always be our Dex. While one can appreciate the strain of being *Pi Magazine's* news editor at the same time, it seems curious that he didn't talk over such a big story with his boss at *Pi*, Rosheen Kabraji. Had he done so, she might have remembered her own coverage of earlier anti-Honderich sentiments in *Pi* last year, and how it was qualified with mention of Honderich denying any anti-Semitism. But apparently, he didn't. It must have been a busy week.

A busy week too, no doubt, for *LS* news editors Angharad Davies and Chaminda Jayanetti. Having (presumably) read Dex's article, they decided that it needed no checking (the job that section editors in real papers are paid to do) and also that it merited their headline 'HONDER-SICK' and a strapline saying that Honderich branded terrorism against Jews "acceptable". Never mind that the article didn't back that up; never mind that the headline and strapline put the rather harmless retired prof somewhere between Heinrich Himmler and Jonathan King. Never mind also that Dex didn't seem to have got approval from Sam for his



Honderich and Dex Torricke-Barton

of the matter regarding the vilified article in question.

Prof. Honderich does not support terrorism the world over. His article 'Terrorism For Humanity' lends support to whatever means he deems necessary for achieving said goal. Terrorist actions that are undertaken in order to achieve the Principle of Humanity are to be thought of as contributing towards terrorism for humanity, hence the article's name. It is this terrorism, and only this terrorism, which Prof. Honderich supports; acts like 9/11 and the hostage situations in Iraq are just as frowned upon by him as by any other human being.

We do not have to agree with

him that the suicide-bombings of Palestinians against Israelis are viable means to any end, no matter how laudable that end may be. No doubt Prof. Honderich would say we have no place to condemn their actions, as we are members of the affluent Western community, and thereby hold collective responsibility for not aiding the Palestinians in their plight. That, however, is all part of the cut and thrust of debate, and it is what makes academic freedom a great thing: that we can disagree over something without lambasting the other side for daring to express an opinion contrary to our own.

One of the vox pops in the *London Student* article claimed that Prof.

continued on page 4

Special report

quotations, given what happened next.

London Student duly appeared, on September 20 or thereabouts. It raised a few eyebrows, and not just because of the exciting new masthead. Prof. Honderich didn't like the coverage of his views on page 2, and Sam Lebens didn't like the way he'd been quoted. In fact, he considered complaining, but decided against an official complaint; instead he wrote to Prof. Honderich to distance himself entirely from the article.

Cue punctilious letter to *LS* editor Alexi Duggins from the prof's solicitors, one Farrer & Co, of 66 Lincoln's Inn Fields, WC2. "It appears that Mr Barton-Torrick [sic] has not read, never mind understood, Prof. Honderich's paper. Had he read and understood it, the clear implication in the articles that Prof. Honderich is anti-Semitic would not have been made", the letter claimed. More importantly, it highlighted inaccuracies such as the fact that Prof. Honderich was not back at UCL this term (being retired) as page 1 suggests. In fact, most of the inaccuracies were on the part of Angharad Davies, who wrote the front page article.

For journalists, inaccuracy is a Very Bad Thing; it violates Article 1 of the Editor's Code of Practice of the Press Complaints Commission

(PCC), which doesn't bind student papers but is worth sticking to. For lawyers, however, inaccuracy is a Very Good Thing because it means a libel case. And this, predictably, is what Farrer & Co waved under Duggins' nose if he didn't immediately publish a reply exactly to Prof. Honderich's requirements and pay his legal costs. What if Duggins had refused? Perhaps the the prof wouldn't have been able to afford a protracted legal struggle (as libel cases can be).

But, bereft of an independent regulator and no doubt under pressure from his paymasters, Duggins caved in. The ensuing reply in the following issue on October 11 – complete with huge and unnecessary picture of Prof. Honderich staring out from page 5 – is far in excess of the PCC's idea of a correction with due prominence, filling as it did the entire page. But this was not a proper newspaper, nor a clash of equals.

Everyone seems quite happy about it now though. Dex beams as he asserts that *London Student* has run up a sizeable legal bill, apparently ignorant of his failure to master some of the most basic tenets of journalism. Honderich appears pacified. And we can all relax in the assurance that the world of student media is just as badly run and regulated as ever. **RL**

The great London Student débacle of '04: page 8



Scary Boots

<scaryboots@tiscali.co.uk>

←← Journalistic Harm-only

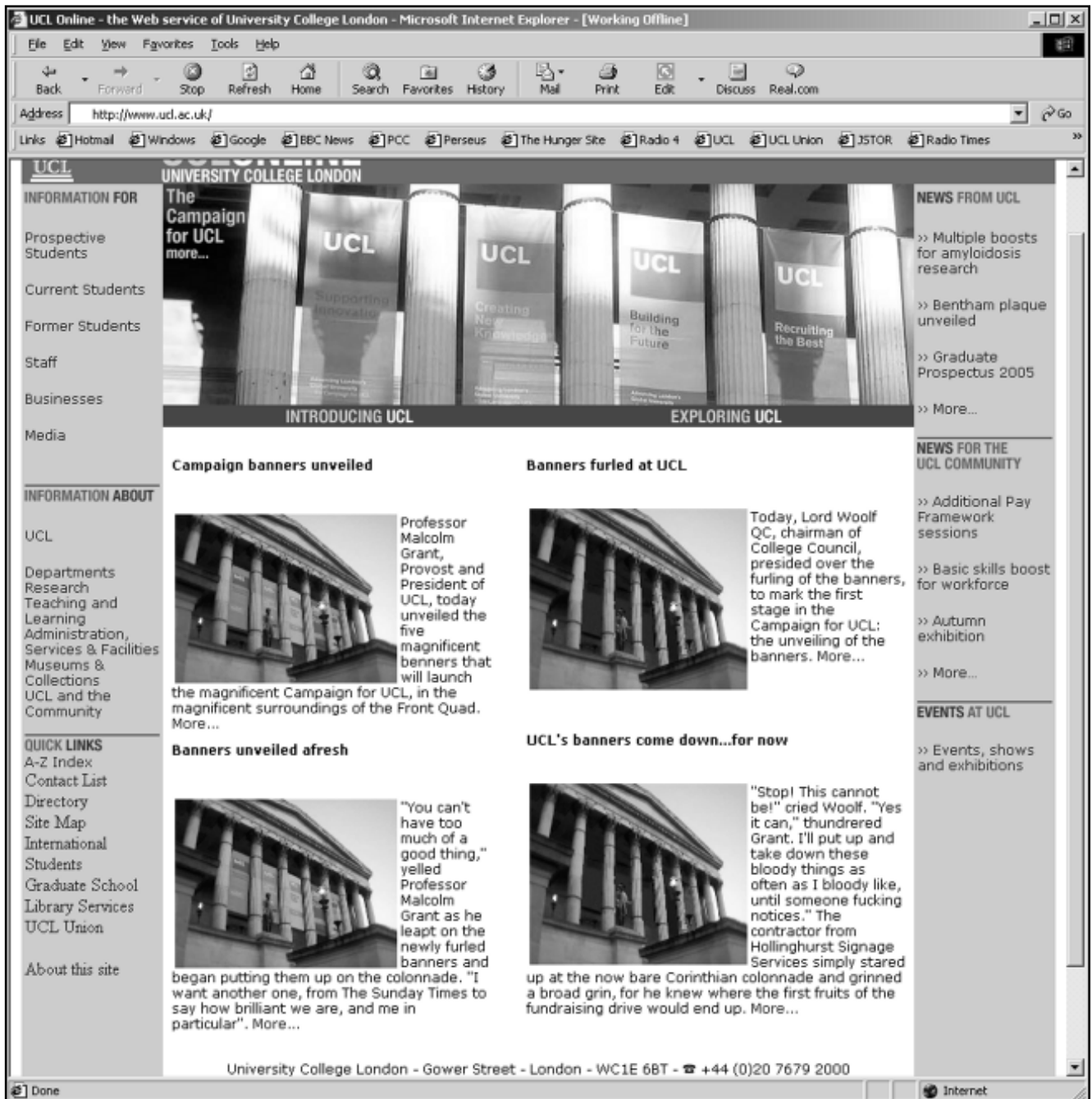
continued from page 3

Honderich's lecture was offensive to all victims of terrorism, including Americans. But how closely did Torricke-Barton bother to read it? Honderich clearly states on a number of occasions throughout his article that 9/11 was wrong. Indeed, for the most part he condemns any form of terrorism. Nowhere in the article was this mentioned. His exception for Palestinian suicide bombers is made because he believes that the Palestinians suffer from Israeli state-terrorism and that their condition could be helped were it not for the majority of Western governments following a

broadly pro-Israeli program in foreign affairs. Given that they can expect no help from the West, their only alternative (as he sees it) is to terrorise those who oppress them. Whether we agree with Prof. Honderich on this really doesn't matter; the point is that he did not simply express an unjustified opinion on the issue as though it were fact, nor was the proposition he made anywhere near as far-reaching as has been stated in bits of *London Student*. He wrote an article that set out his views and the reasons he has for holding them. As intelligent readers, it should be up to us to decide

whether or not we agree; if not, we should remember that we don't have to like it.

It is not for journalists to make up our minds for us, not when their sources consist of a few straggly words dressed up in quotation marks and spun into a story so far removed from truth as to be almost unrecognisable. Academics, like anybody else, are free to say what they wish. Above all, they are entitled to the respect of having their speeches heard and their writings read in full, and described accurately by all parties. Prof. Honderich is no exception.



A big black waste of space

UCL News: so useless, you can't even make a paper plane with it

HERE AT UCL, we don't go in for media in a big way. Down at Imperial, in addition to the official college paper, the *IC Reporter*, there are three weekly newspapers and a well-kept news website, Live! Whereas we at UCL have *Pi Magazine* (the Union thing) and *UCL News* (the college thing). Unfortunately, *Pi* is unable to cover news, being monthly, and *UCL News* is controlled by a bunch of narrow-minded staff. The sole purpose of this largely empty paper, printed on expensively black paper for no ap-

parent reason, is to aggrandise the activities of the Provost and his staff, however trivial they may be. And so student news goes unreported. In April, *The Times*' website reported that Bartlett student Dan Brady had had an architectural model bought by millionaire art collector Charles Saatchi. Incredibly, UCL's futile media relations office didn't notice. *UCL News* was too busy telling us about how they'd given Lynne Truss a fellowship. Well, hooray for Truss; I bet she desperately needs recognition

with that bestselling punctuation book.

Last term, then media and communications sabb Andreas von Maltzahn tried to start an independent UCL newspaper. He failed, because College refused the money. Well, we have an idea. According to an estimate from Bam UK, *Pi*'s printers, *UCL News* costs about twelve grand a year. How about scrapping that black white elephant and using the money to fund a newspaper that takes some notice of student achievements? **RL**

The Campaign for Giving Us Your Fucking Money

UCL has hit upon a bold and original idea in British higher education. It is going to beg for money. Nick Cowen forks out



UCL Provost and President Malcolm Grant tries his hand at selling worthless publications to his own staff, in a shining example of the new progressive fundraising drive.

issue, of Pi - Ed.). They ought to be able to spare a few grand. Then, once we've pissed them off, we will start on friends, family and colleagues. But I don't see why we have to stop there. When we have made everyone ashamed to even know us — I've already done this with my mother-in-law — we will accost members of the public until they give us a few pence just to make us go away. Grant explained his philanthropic underlying motives: "Just look at the United States. Harvard have got tons of money, but I'm stuck over here. For Christ's sake." The provost then set off towards Euston Station, wandering up to random members of the public saying, "Hello, I'm sorry to bother you, I'm not begging, I just need a couple of pounds for the Tube..."

BRITISH UNIVERSITIES must look to the fundraising efforts of the homeless and drug-addled, UCL's provost warned this week.

As UCL launches its "Advancing London's University Global Cash Grab" campaign, Professor Malcolm Grant, provost and president of UCL, spoke of the seemingly British attitude

towards begging on the street: "We need, in the university sector, to actively develop a culture of begging for funds." "Naturally, we will start by begging off alumni," Grant enthused, "particularly the rich ones like Ricky Gervais and that bloke from Coldplay (*Mr Grant was evidently unable at the time to lay his hands on an issue, any*

Stuff we dug up from a bin

In a sensational reinterpretation of the terms of the Data Protection Act, we take a look inside the e-mail inbox of Professor Steve Jones...

-----Original Message -----

From: "Arkansas Smith"
<arkansassmith@koolgenetic-
s4kids.net>

To: "Steve Jones"
<candiefloss69@ucl.ac.uk>

Subject: PhD research
post...pretty please!

Dear Prof. Steve Jones,
I hope you do not mind my writing to you! For I know you are a most

prodigiously busy man, what with your sporadic appearances on Newsnight (how is the lovely Kirsty Wark by the way?), in fact your general permanence on our illuminated screens, and — of course — your most beloved and respected popular science books. However, it has not escaped my notice that you are advertising for a PhD student to work on your animal of choice, the noble and admirable Cepaea snail. And you know what? I think I would be per-

fect for the post. I'm from K**gs you know, studying B****gy, and all my friends think I'm a bit mad!!!

You might be wondering why you should give me the post. Well, genetics has always captured the imagination of my fully-formed mind; it must date from my seeing Jurassic Park for the first time ever. The splendour and glory of those dinos! Oh, the unfortunate critters, dealt such a cruel blow by fate. I have to confess that it has always been

*Gaze over at the opposite page if
you can still bear to read*

Another World Yawn is Possible

MEETINGS *bloody* MEETINGS

A review of the most exciting things ever to happen in lecture theatres

This month, the European Social Forum descended on the intellectual hub of London. Nick Cowen witnessed the exciting events...



A rare lull in the fervour of Thursday's hot lecture action in the A V Lecture Theatre

THE AV LECTURE THEATRE was thronged with literally several people on Thursday 7th October, as students came to ask the interestingly phrased question "No War!" at the European Social Forum. The discussion heard a diverse range of views, varying all the way from "Bush is a chimp, free Palestine" to "Free Palestine, Bush is a chimp." All pledged to bore their colleagues far into the future for the sake of a better world as waves of melatonin emanated from the lecture theatre, sending

all, even those out of earshot, into premature sleep.

The assembled comrades praised Professor Steve Jones as he valiantly stood up to the irrational Creationist beliefs in America by humorously comparing Bush to a primate, proving evolution conclusively once again. This was a forward thinking discussion that wished to disabuse the world (and the US) of unfounded religious beliefs. The praise was even higher, however, for Ted Honderich as he supported Islamic fundamental-

ists whose "terrorism for humanity" is helping to secure the creation of a liberated Palestinian state where belief in Allah, Adam and Eve will be mandatory (*can this be right?* - Ed). Er... this was a forward thinking discussion eager to free the world of Western dominated Neo-Zionist-implicated beliefs such as science, rationality and freedom. The Cheese Grater wishes you the best of luck, comrades.



my ambition to create something truly awesome - a live dino. Just one, of course - we by no means want rampaging dinos all over the shop! As you can tell the moral and practical messages of Jurassic Park have not passed me by...Actually, come to think of it, the subjection of one dino to a life of earthly loneliness is a bit cruel. And a paucity of ethics, I think you'll agree, is against everything modern genetics and UCL stand for! Maybe two dinos then? My God, we could even have fights à la Pokemon! (poke-'im-mon!). Food for thought, no? Dinosaurs: more alluring than snails? Hope to hear from

you soon!

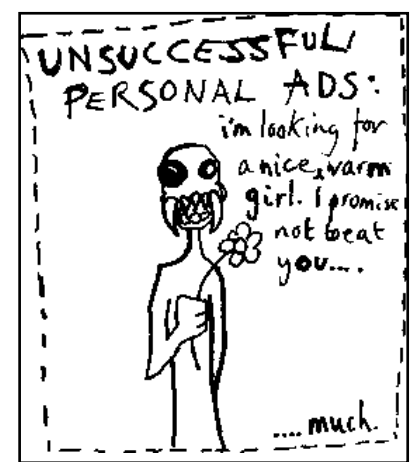
Yours truly,
Arkansas Smith

P.S. A copy of my CV is enclosed.
P.P.S. I greatly enjoyed your talk at the European Socialists' Forum meeting! Now, if only we could get hold of some Cro-Magnon man DNA...

It's fast, it's easy and it's free. Get cloning your kid brother/sister today!
http://www.koolgenetics-4kids.net/legal_disclaimer.html

No no no, Biology researcher wrote this.

Personal

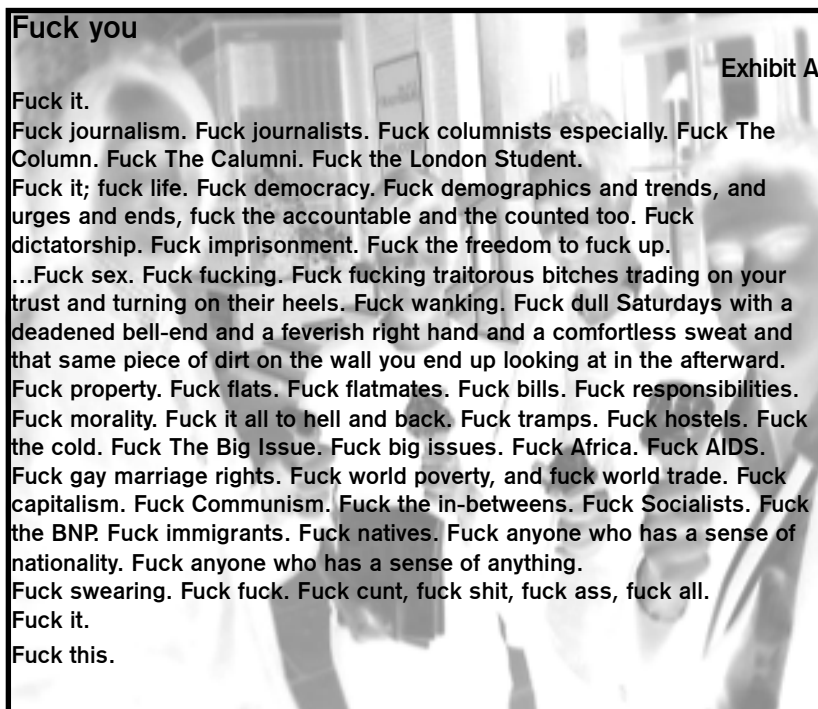


Scary Boots
<scaryboots@tiscali.co.uk>

Special report

The great *London Stu-*

Last year, King's College London Students' Union banned *London* principle of press freedom on its head. How did this happen? *The* minutes of the Eighth ULU Council are out, a tale of incompetence



mailed ULU Council, telling them he was banning *London Student* – for that one article. “May I register my disgust at this irresponsible and despicable article,” Dunne spluttered. “Any article which gratuitously and unnecessarily uses the word f**k (75 times) [sic] and treats issues such as HIV so glibly and irresponsibly should not be allowed to appear in any Newspaper, let alone one which is paid for by the students of the University of London”. He went on, to then *LS* editor Lila Allen: “please do not send any copies to King’s, we do not wish to stock this issue thank you and any received will be duly recycled”. The issue became widely discussed – at least on student message boards. Events came to a head at the last meeting of ULU Council of 2003/04 on June 1st. A motion of censure had been brought against Allen. It was defeated. Another motion, brought by her and defending her position, was carried, by 17 votes to 15. The second motion was itself signed by dozens of supporters, including 18 officers from the University’s many colleges as well as *LS* contributors.

Why were all these people expressing such strong views over one article which, had it been overlooked, could have been dismissed as meaningless? Had such passions - enough to keep thirty-eight dedicated people voting in the dining hall at Imperial College Union for over two hours that night – arisen from nowhere?

A little history

Stephen Fingleton is someone most people who dip their toe into student politics at UCL eventually comes up against.

The high jinks of student unions, whilst interesting to other students, are of little import to the supposedly more cut-and-thrust world outside. And yet last summer, one particular student bunfight, centred on the hallowed halls of Malet Street, WC1, and of Surrey Street, WC2, made its way into the real, professional mass media. Not just the EducationGuardian website – which covers all SU events, not least UCL’s, quite obsequiously – but *The Guardian*’s student print edition, *The Daily Telegraph* (twice) and *The Times Higher Education Supplement*. And it all happened when a UCL student wrote an article in with the word ‘fuck’ in it quite a lot. How could it matter? And why does it still matter? Herein lies a story not just about what our lords and masters do on the fourth floor of the ULU building, but about how student unions do and don’t work, and whether we have any

hope of freedom in a little world fraught with divisions, alliances and the enemy, bureaucracy...

The ban

Here’s what everyone knows. On 25 May, the last issue of *London Student* for the year was published by ULU. The executive committee, commonly known as ULU Exec, simultaneously issued a statement distancing themselves from its content. “Specifically,” it said, “we wish to apologise to any one who is offended by the language or the quality of the article on the left-hand column of page 8 of the current edition.” The column in question was the regular opinion piece penned by Stephen Fingleton of UCL (Exhibit A). As you can see, it contains the word ‘fuck’ 77 times, excluding the title. Why they objected to it is anyone’s guess, but on the same day, David Dunne, president of King’s College Students’ Union (KCLSU) e-

dent débâcle of '04

Student from their grounds, in a move which seemed to turn the *Cheese Grater* has been investigating for months. Now that the and shady motives at ULU has been revealed...

THE PROTAGONISTS



STEPHEN FINGLETON (UCL)

London Student comment editor, 2003-04

As columnist, Fingleton was notoriously his own man. Very critical of students' unions and their structures, but was his controversial streak driven more by nihilism than a desire to change the status quo?

DAVID DUNNE (KCL)
President, KCLSU, 2003-04

Whether motivated by his equal opps policy or a covert plan to smear Lila Allen and Fingleton (for whom he has little love), the decision to ban *LS* was Dunne's alone.



LILA ALLEN (QMUL)

London Student editor, 2003-04

As Fingleton's overseer, Allen consistently defended him and her own judgement. In publishing his final column, she risked tainting an illustrious track record in student and professional journalism.

CHRIS PIPER (KCL)
President, ULU, 2003-04

Piper was one of the first ULU officers to voice concern over the final Column. His e-mails show he wanted to block it. As a consequence, events up to and including June's ULU council have damaged his credibility in the eyes of some London student officers.



the London *Evening Standard*, he successfully persuaded many people that he was married to Shania Twain. But Joly did not have students' union officers to contend with. Nemesis was on its way.

How not to censor a newspaper

London Student enjoys effective editorial independence – the content does not necessarily represent, blah blah – but the editor is a ULU sabbatical officer, and is answerable to ULU Council. And so it seems that, when people over the course of the year had a complaint to make about *LS*, they complained not to the editor, but to ULU. Fine; but that shouldn't have stopped the complaints from being passed on to the editor. And so it was that, when ULU Exec met on May 4th this year, they had some issues with the paper. Well, with Fingleton's column, actually. According to the distinctly vague Exec minutes, it was agreed by the eight officers there that ULU is harmed when *LS* offends people, and ULU should be able to intervene. The article where Fingleton purported to have cut his arm open at NUS Conference – a fabrication – was said to have “undermined ULU's educational work with mental health charities”. Yet no letter had been sent to the paper. Were these eight people representing the views of students across London, or merely their own? Chris Piper, then president of ULU, told *The Cheese Grater*: “Of course they express the concerns of the people at the executive there. They are elected officers; they do represent students across the University of London”. Trouble is, do elected officers seek out and then represent the views of the student body as a whole? Do ours?

In his second year, the hirsute Ulsterman both wrote a column (“The Column”) in *LS* and edited the opinion page. Fingleton is an opinionated man (‘he’s a fuckin’ cock’ is a favourite character appraisal), he dabbles in many art forms, from electronic music to film, and his attitude is often decidedly sphinx-like. Unsurprisingly then, the content of The Column defied convention and acceptance. When his meaning was clear, it was clearly brutal. After attacking the Irish, UCL Union coffee (and all those who served it) and abortion without pausing for breath, he built up a healthy chorus of disapprovers who read and hated his column all over London. The letters

flowed in. They did not like his views on the Irish, nor his proclivity for talking about masturbation. And when he wrote about being charged with murder, some people got really worried. “Eventually,” Fingleton reflected, “a question was raised at ULU Council about the article over the possibility of libel. Editor Lila Allen noted the article could not be ‘libellous’ as the girl did not exist.” And there’s the point: much of what Fingleton wrote was a big joke, a grotesque jab at his critics to preserve the momentum of what he’d started and a Baudrillardesque subversion of reported truth. This has, of course, been done in newspapers before: when Dom Joly wrote a column in

Special report

ULU Exec made the incredible assertion that “LS should not print any more articles from this columnist”. Also, “it was suggested that the Editor may be intimidated by the columnist in question”. Finally, it was agreed that the union general manager and incoming editor Alexi Duggins would prepare a strategy paper for *London Student*. What does the strategy paper have to do with the complaints? Lila Allen was not told of either and, not being on Exec, had no particular way of finding out. If Exec appears to agree to something in its minutes, that usually amounts to policy. But Exec has no right to pronounce editorial policy at *London Student*! Piper admitted as much later, but why didn’t he clear it up at the meeting?

So, nearly a month before the offending issue was banned by King’s, the majority of ULU Exec wanted Fingleton out, and were happy to discuss this, along with other issues relating to the paper, behind Allen’s back.

Subsequent to this meeting, Lila Allen met the general manager and Chris Piper for a routine meeting. In an interview for *The Cheese Grater* in June, Piper told us that Allen brought up the subject of Fingleton’s mental health. But according to Allen, the first question she was asked was if she was afraid of Fingleton. This she denied. Nor did she have much time for the idea that the tales of self-harm and masturbation were a “clear cry for help”. Piper apologised for any misunderstanding. Who’s lying so far? If Allen, she may have been trying to cover up for secretly thinking Fingleton off his head. But if Piper lied, a more sinister picture emerges: of an agenda being slowly advanced, an agenda to discredit his fellow sabb.

Fingleton wrote his momentarily famous ‘fuck you’ article on 17 May. As per usual, ULU Exec saw an advance copy of the paper, on Friday 21 May. At this stage, of course, no-one outside Malet Street had seen the finished paper, and hardly anyone had had a chance to read The Column. Piper immediately objected to the article (Exhibit B). Lila claims that Piper asked her to remove all the

Exhibit B

Did Piper really think that the word ‘fuck’ could be removed from Fingleton’s article? Lila Allen seems to think so. But it would have left a column even Tara Palmer-Tomkinson might shudder to file...



swearwords. This wouldn’t have left much (Exhibit A again), except the ensuing thank-yous. Piper denies he said this. Exhibit B, however, suggests otherwise. By the end of Friday, it would have been clear that the article was going in.

The King’s Sieve

At least three members or ex-members of KCLSU, including president Piper himself, sat on ULU Exec in the 2003/04 season. Everyone, including then KCLSU student affairs vice-president Toby Boon, agrees that one of the Exec members decided to leak *London Student* to their lord and master, KCLSU president David Dunne. Why was it leaked, and why to Dunne? The events are explained if we hypothesise that Chris Piper wanted to hit back at *London Student*. After alienating ULU Council by stubbornly opposing a top-up fees demo, Piper probably couldn’t rely on many people in Council to help him out,

unless he had rewarded them in some way. And it so happened that, earlier in May, Piper had done just that: he’d bestowed the prestigious President’s Award of honorary life membership of ULU, for outstanding contribution thereto, on...his successor as KCLSU president, David Dunne. For what? According to fellow ULU Exec member and then medical students’ officer Johann Malawana, for “doing nothing”.

It was not until the ULU Exec meeting of May 24th that Lila Allen found out about the statement prepared by Exec. The statement said, *inter alia*: “We...accept that as a consequence of this [editorial independence] sometimes what is published will be critical of elected officers and SUs or of poor quality in our opinion.” Not only did ULU Exec feel that the disclaimer about ULU printed in every issue was not enough, but they felt able to speak on behalf of the entire union; a remarkable feat for eight people. The next day, David Dunne took president’s action to ban

the paper. As Dunne said at the time and Toby Boon later told us, the article was considered in breach of KCLSU's equal opportunities policy: "I felt there was a breach of the equal opportunities, because of the blatant dismissal of people's core values and belief systems, in a way that it was very, very difficult to have any kind of right to reply". The sheer meaninglessness of such statements as "fuck gay marriage rights" in the context of the article appeared to have passed him by. Dunne claimed in the *EducationGuardian* that "we had complaints from students who felt uncomfortable because of this article". That would have meant students wandering into his office and reading the advance copy, which is exactly what Boon told *The Cheese Grater* they did do; but there can't have been that many of King's 18,000 population trooping in and out of the sabbatical office in Surrey Street that day. The newspaper was threatened with being pulped, just as UCL had done with *London Student* in 2001, and Dunne directed his minions to draft a motion of censure against Lila Allen, to be submitted to the next ULU Council on 1 June, even though it was only a week away on 25 May and the deadline for motions had passed.

The Fight Back

If Chris Piper and David Dunne could be seen as part of a faction, then it inevitably follows that Lila Allen had one of her own. Fingleton and friends immediately rallied to the cause, vowing to put their own motion (*vide* UCL Union message board). Between 25 May and 1 June, Allen drafted her own (emergency) motion for ULU Council, "Freedom of the Press". It is probably at this time that she also alerted her contacts in the national press to the unfolding story. Someone even managed to ring up John Peel and get him to condemn the King's censorship; and (no doubt through Allen's chum Simon Hogg at Canary Wharf) the story eventually made its way onto *The Daily Telegraph*. Whether we believe Fingleton, who said someone tried to get a statement from Terry Wogan, is

another matter. It may just be one of his Irish jokes.

The Reckoning

David Dunne was not present at ULU Council when it convened in the Beit Quad on Prince Consort Road on the evening of Tuesday 1 June. Toby Boon was there to represent him, and to deliver a motion of censure he insists it gave him no pleasure to propose. Though late, it was introduced as an emergency measure, and its validity is debatable. In the opposite corner was Olivier Usher, UCL Union councillor and *LS* features editor, wielding a motion for Lila Allen, who was herself present. But the motions had to wait. By all accounts it was a lively meeting: "Lila Allen didn't put her bloody delegate card down once," a King's observer later wrote. Both advocates and critics of Allen and friends agree that the meeting was endlessly delayed by a barrage of procedural motions, apparently brought by both sides in an attempt to make each other's supporters give up and go home. Only after hours of bobbing up and down were the key motions arrived at. Matt Cooke, then ULU officer and current president, made a speech in favour of not putting the motion of censure, and instead proposing a review of *London Student*. But by then, both sides were too far gone. The motion of censure crawled over a barbed wire fence of five procedural motions, one guillotine vote (a vote to extend the maximum running time of the meeting) and even a quorum count, only to be defeated by 18 votes to 12. Then came the return punch. The motion on freedom of the press was tied the first time round; on a revote, it was passed by one. Boon and Piper expressed their disappointment at the conduct of the meeting; in response, Allen said: "Not sure whether Chris is disappointed that the censure against me didn't go through or that I won my motion? Who knows?"

So What?

The old guard are gone. Perhaps Chris Piper will land his plum

job at UNISON; perhaps Lila Allen will get on Channel 4 News like she so dearly wants to. But this episode was crucially important. Firstly, had Allen been censured, it would have set a remarkable precedent for the regulation of *LS*; namely that it is subject to the whim of college student unions. The paper's relationship with student officers and staff is sticky enough as it is; it needs more independence, not less. Only an independent adjudicator can offer both safety for the paper's editor and credible regulation for its readership; but this seems impossible to fulfil under students' union conditions. If, however, ULU's constituent bodies had behaved themselves, *London Student* might never have been banned in the first place. At best, the activities of Piper, Dunne and co. are typical of the officiousness of student officers, so often more eager to run lofty-sounding campaigns and search for breaches in their protocols than to make students feel part of something big. At worst, they amount to a connivance to discredit both Lila Allen and Stephen Fingleton. Rob Park, now a ULU sabbatical officer, expressed at the time his "sneaking suspicion" that there was a "witch-hunt" going on.

Students do not fund their unions to engage in such petty point-scoring as occurred at ULU in the summer. More importantly, they deserve not to have their activities and channels of expression choked and tied up by distant sabbaticals with dubious motives and no idea of how journalism works, even in reduced, student form. *London Student*, as has been pointed out, is an amenity, a facility for London students to use and read. It is not a ULU newsletter, and however much ULU's masters may agree with that, it has not stopped them from illogically, stealthily and unacceptably interfering with the freedom of the press. These were our elected officers; and if we get the student officers we deserve, we all have something to answer for.

Have things got better? See page two. **RL**

XFM to save...er, what, exactly?

A recent article in *London Student* painted a rather rosy picture of XFM bailing out student radio. Too rosy for the bloke actually IN the picture...



Hey, Ed! Bet you didn't know XFM are bailing you out. The funniest part is, they don't know either!

ON 2 AUGUST THIS year, London-based radio station XFM put out a press release saying it was "throwing a lifeline" to student radio after the collapse of their main funder, the Student Broadcasting Network (SBN). This was reported, somewhat flatteringly, on *Guardian Unlimited*. Then along came *London Student* news editor Chaminda Jayanetti, who decided to write about it. Or, to be more accurate, he decided to copy out the *Guardian* article without bothering to acknowledge it and then get one measly quotation from someone at Goldsmith's. Bless you,

Cham; we know you're a nice man (even though you're from Strand Poly) and capable of writing better than this; but the fact is, your plagiarism has caught you out.

XFM are not about to just start giving student radio stations money. As Matt Treacy, secretary of the Student Radio Association, told *The Cheese Grater*, XFM offers a different deal to each station, subject to discussion and in return for the station playing XFM's night sustainer service. Apart from 'funding for licences and radio equipment', XFM make no mention of giving money.

The article found few friends at UCL's radio station Rare FM, which needs to make up a £3000 shortfall after SBN's demise. When the article appeared, Rare FM treasurer Fiona [INSERT] could be heard sounding off about XFM in the Clubs and Societies Centre. And not surprisingly: although XFM are not supporting Rare FM in any way, shape or form, the article was illustrated with a photo of a DJ, recognisable to many as Rare FM head of programming Ed Jefferson, who promptly e-mailed *The Cheese Grater* to tell us of this. "I wasn't told it had anything to do with the XFM story," he insisted, "just that they wanted a picture of the Rare FM studio!" Nor does Rare FM station manager Frankie Roberto expect much help from the station. "I think the main reason XFM are looking to act as a student sustainer service is simply to promote their radio station to students outside London...I doubt they'd be as interested in supporting us as we're London based anyway." He concludes: "Whilst it's great that they're offering some support ...they're not filling the gap SBN left by a long way." RL

Party pooper: UCL boy screws up Tories

Stringfellow's proved not the luckiest place for a wannabe politico...

ON FRIDAY 1 OCTOBER, the UCL Union Conservative Society's typically glitzy term card gushed, there would be a "champagne and canapés reception" at Stringfellow's nightclub. And so there was, and Mr Peter Stringfellow himself (a notable Tory donor) made some witty comments about Tony Blair's heart condition. What did he say again?... I can't quite remember, it was all a little hazy...

Oh yes, that's it.



London branch (new name for the Young Conservatives).

Fortunately for society president Alan Ross, it wasn't his party. The UCL Tories were attending an event hosted by Conservative-Future West

So who organised this party? Step forward CF West leader, UCL's very own Annesley Abercorn of SSEES! It is understood that Tory Central Office have not hired him for PR yet. RL



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The views expressed herein are not necessarily those of UCL Union. In fact, they're probably not.